Only Superman Onstage

By Daniel Tosh

INTRODUCTION

No moment in popular culture is more charged and anxious than when a stand-up comic battles with a heckler. It usually ends with a knockout insult and a huge laugh. But when things turn ugly, it can expose the gap between comedians and patrons who see this clash very differently. In Only Superman Onstage, Daniel Tosh shares a true story from his life on the road as a stand-up comic and one heckler who took things from the venue to the road. Only Superman Onstage by Daniel Tosh

In 2002, I emceed a Battle of the Bands at a college in Lakeview, Florida. I thought it would be fun, kind of like *American Idol*, and I could make fun of each band a little bit after it had performed.

What I didn't realize was that the only people who showed up at these things were friends of the people performing. They don't want to hear some stranger belittle their friends right after they've performed.

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The show was going on and we were having a good time. Then some guy really just went into me, heckling and screaming at me. So I went right back into him. He wouldn't quit, so I had them turn the houselights up and offered him a microphone if he wanted to continue. It wasn't a fun exchange, like in a comedy club. This was pretty angry and violent.

He said, "Who do you think you are?" I was just like, "I'm the guy who they're paying a lot of money to make fun of your friend's band."

Onstage, a comedian can be fearless. You get all that laughter from so many people and start to feel superhuman, invincible. So I didn't hesitate before I said something like, "I'll kill you and all your friends." I was so drunk with thoughts of immortality that it never occurred to me somebody out there might be saying, "Okay. We're gonna wait outside for this guy afterwards."

Sure enough, the show ended and I was walking outside to the care with my little college-girl student sponsor, who noticed very quickly that, "Hey, there's

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that guy." And there was the heckler with a crew of guys. He was probably about fifty yards away from me, screaming, "Com one, let's fight!" I yelled back, "Oh, no. I'm busy," and told the student "Okay, let's go to the car. Now. Qu8ickly." The entire group started running toward us. And that's when I transformed from the powerful comic to the scared little *guy* who had needed to become a comic in the first place.

Seconds after we took off, they were on our bumper, and I realized that the student was driving me to my hotel and got a big dose of pure fear. "Hey, you *do* know these guys are really trying to kill me, right?" She kept right on driving the speed limit, straight to my hotel. Suddenly this carload of guys pulled into the lane next to us, screaming for us to pull over. She began to realize that maybe something unusual was happening. "What are we going to do?"

"Well, for starters, we're not going to pull over."

Then the guy who wanted to kill me waved a gun out of his window, and she still stopped at the next red light.

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By now I'd stopped trying to look cool and was just yelling at her, "Run the light! They're pointing a *gun* at us!" and she said, "No. I could get a ticket." I was trying to enlighten her: "Yes. Yes. We *want* police now."

Finally she got it, ran the light, and started speeding and ducking into backroads trying to lose them. After watching this fresh-faced college girl turn from law-abiding citizen to demonic driver, I'm convinced everyone has the ability to lead a high-speed chase, given the proper motivation.

I guess the heckler and his posse were pretty motivated, because they stayed right with us. Suddenly my driver screeched to a halt in front of my hotel and smiled at me like, "We made it." Meanwhile, they were pulling up right behind us, and I started yelling, "Go! Go!" Finally I called 911 from my cell. Conscious of the fact that they play those recordings back, I was trying not to act too scared. "Oh, yes. Hi. Well, you see, we seem to have some crazies driving next to us with a gun. We really could use your help. We're going to stay in the car

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just driving around until a cop intercepts us." And that's what happened – a patrol car showed up, my pursuers took off, and another cop went and followed them. I said, "That's it. I'm not staying at that hotel." The 911 operator said, "Yeah, the cop just found them circling your hotel."

When I got into the police car, the college girl reacted just as if we'd driven back to the hotel from having a tuna melt, instead of being chased there by gun-toting lunatics. She just smiled at me and said, "Okay, it was nice meeting you. Hopefully you can come back next year."

So I had a police escort take me to the hotel and go up to my room with me and pack all my stuff. I even got a police escort back to the freeway, where I drove to my brother's house in Orlando. And I curled up in bed with him and cried. For the next six months, all hecklers got from me was a smile, "God bless you," and the next joke.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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